POSITION SPECIFIC TRAINING:

"Don't be good at it, be the best at it!"

Props: "The Beasts"

- They have to be big and strong.
- Their ability to scrum well and to get around the field for support is also vital.
- They must possess correct scrumming techniques and be able to apply them consistently.
- Often the success of the lineout depends on their consistent lifting and timing with the jumper.
- Rucking skills are important (cleaning out).
- Need to use their strength in power plays to turn over ball (counter ruck) or disrupt the opposition's defences by a powerful ball carry.

Special Individual Practice:

The success of any scrum is on the hit during the engagement. The front row must remember to keep their knees in front of their toes while squatting, remember to bar up. During the scrum they must bend their knees, this helps them get a straight back. Everyone must have their heads up and be bound tightly.

The individual practice that I have chosen for props can be beneficial for the entire team. Two players face each other an equal distance from a line. They squat by bending at the knees and concentrate on their knees being in front of their toes. If they are correctly in this position they should slowly be falling forward. On the call they engage. On the engagement they must see who can engage first and who can knock their opponent away from the line from the hit. It is important that all the proper techniques are followed; knees bent, straight back and head up.

When practicing the correct scrumming techniques they can start off with each of them having a hand on the ground to keep them up, but eventually they should be able to balance without any hands on the ground.

Hooker: “The Middle Man”

- Ability to find his jumper and to hook the ball is of utmost importance.
- Must throw in consistently and accurately.
- Must also possess lots of skill and pace.
- He must be able to act as an extra loose forward.
- Perfect cross between a prop (strength) and a loose forward (mobility).
- Team leader in the scrums.
- Needs to be fearless in everything he does (aggressive).
- Must be a great communicator.
- Applies pressure on opposing halves from the lineout.

Special Individual Practice:

The most important thing about a hooker is his hooking and throwing in ability. I have chosen two special individual practices for him.

Firstly is his hooking in a scrum. The hooker leans against a pole with his right shoulder in a scrumming position. The coach puts the ball in and the hooker must strike as quickly as possible while hooking the ball.

Secondly is the hooker’s throwing. This can be practiced on any wall or on the cross bar of the poles. A hooker must decide what technique he is using, throwing with one hand or with two. Good practice for the hooker if he is throwing with two hands is throwing straight into the air above him. This will help him to see whether the ball is spinning properly.

Locks: “The Twin Towers”

- They must be tall and have good jumping skills.
- Must also possess good ball handling skills and ability to scrum.
- Ability to catch the ball from the kick off is important.
- Rucking skills are important (cleaning out).
- Fulfils a similar role as the props but should possess similar characteristics as a loose forward.
- Must always be on the look out for a lineout steal by reading the opponents lineout.

Special Individual Practice:

Even though we are allowed lifting in the lineout the lock must still jump. A lock must be able to beat his opponent off the ground. To improve this, the lock needs to work on his explosiveness.

The first individual practice is standing under the cross bar, jumping and touching it. The lock can start off touching the cross bar with either hand and then with both hands at the same time. A rule of thump when it comes to lineout play is if the lock can touch the ball he can catch it.

Brilliant explosive exercises for the whole team is hopping, jumping, squats and squat jumps. A lock can stand side on to a tackling bag and can jump off both feet over the bag for 2 minutes.

Jumping and Timing Drill:

Set up two pods. The first pod jumps with the ball, when the lock is in the air he throws it to the next pod, which jumps and catches it. The first pod then jumps again to receive it again (repeat). This is a great exercise, but will take time.

Loose forwards: “The Predators”

- Extremely skilful and have lots of pace.
- Must be good defenders.
- They must have good running off ability (ball carry) and skill to link with support.
- Rucking skills, in particular at the breakdown (turnovers).
- Act as link between backs and forwards.
- Apply pressure.
- Play as a unit.

Special Individual Practice:

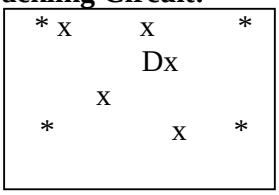
In today’s game, these players still have to be the fittest players on the field. They are the perfect cross between a back and a tight forward. Any fitness exercises will be extremely beneficial to them. The loose forwards make some of the highest tackle counts during a game. This is why for their special practice I have chosen tackling drills, which are obviously beneficial to the entire team.

Tackling is an area of the game where players have to build up confidence. They have to be coached properly on all the different tackling techniques. A good way to start is from scratch. Player’s facing each other, the defenders on their knees and the attackers jogging at them. Tackling with either shoulder is practiced. This is eventually built up into full on contact. A player must be able to tackle equally with either shoulder. Tackling head on, the defender must choose which shoulder to use and get his head out of the way. If a defender tackles with his left shoulder, his left leg must also carry most of his own weight. The clamping of the arms is the next thing. The right arm must lift the attacker’s leg and then twist the defender to the ground. Like tackling head on, from the side the defender must get his head out of the way and then the same steps are followed. If a defender can get both his feet off the ground, like a missile, he will be certain to take down an opponent.

Tackling can be broken up into three stages; the first being shutting down the attackers space, then the American football zone where the defender’s weight is being passed to either foot, and then finally the launching stage when the defender decides which shoulder to use. It is important to get your feet up and to keep your studs on the ground for as long as possible. Like all contact situations you must always have your eyes open.

If the attacking player has not had much space to move the defender can tackle the ball i.e. above the waist. This is often referred to as a smother tackle. The defender must make sure that he has players on his inside and outside.

Tackling Circuit:



Demarcate an area with cones. The defender has 2 minutes to tackle as many times as possible, while the tackled players try and evade (great fitness drill). All the tackling techniques can be practiced.

Scrumhalf: "The Playmaker"

- They need brilliant vision and possess amazing distributing skills.
- Creativity is important.
- Communicates well with the forwards and backs (vital link between them).
- Should always be close to the ball, within 5 metres at all times.
- Must quickly sum up the different situations on the field.
- Needs to execute all skills quickly and well under pressure.
- Defensively must be capable to tackle a forward.
- Plays a covering role on defence watching for any grubbers, chips or line breaks.
- Must be able to read oppositions play.
- Often has to keep the pressure off the flyhalf and his team.
- General kicking skills are important, especially kicking from the base.

Special Individual Practice:

This player's pass is the most important thing to the team. He must learn to pass accurately off the ground and dive pass either way. Reverse passing is another pass the scrumhalf should practice.

When passing off the ground his rear foot must be close to the ball and his feet should be well spread apart. This should prevent him from having to wind-up.

A good practice for the scrumhalf; is placing a whole lot of balls in line and a man standing about ten meters away. The scrumhalf passes the balls to him; the receiver shouldn't have to move while he places them down again in a line. Passing off the ground and dive passing can be practiced. Another man can be introduced to pop the balls to the scrumhalf or roll them, before he passes (simulating a ball off the top from the lineout or a ball bouncing on the ground).

His ability to kick from the base of a scrum, ruck or maul is also vital to relieve the pressure off the flyhalf. The timing for a box kick can be practiced with the wing/chaser. It is important that the timing is right to prevent an offside situation during a game (chaser in front of the kicker).

Fly-half: “The General”

- Needs brilliant vision and must posses amazing distributing skills.
- Good communicator on attack and defence.
- Creative.
- Great kicking skills and ability to kick of either foot is important.
- Good feet i.e. stepping.
- Dictates how the game needs to be played therefore must be able to quickly sum up where the strengths or weaknesses are on attack or defence.
- Consistently makes quick decisions under pressure.
- Must be able to react quickly to rectify his own mistakes or of his team-mates.
- Create space for outside backs by drawing opposing loose forwards.
- Keep the forwards in the game.

Special Individual Practice:

This is the position in the team where the player puts himself under pressure to create space for the team. Like the scrumhalf his distributing skills are important and equally are his boot.

Special practice for the flyhalf would be his line kicking which can be practiced with the fullback. Introducing a defender preferably a loose forward to apply pressure would be advantageous.

Another good practice is running onto the ball and receiving it at different positions from the scrumhalf. Their communication is very important.

Passing drills and drills that apply pressure are good.

Kicking Accuracy Drill:

Set up demarcated areas with 4 cones and the kicker practices kicking the ball to the area. All kicking skills can be practiced e.g. grubber, chip, line kick etc. Vary the distance of the areas.

Centres: “The Line Breakers and Off-Loaders”

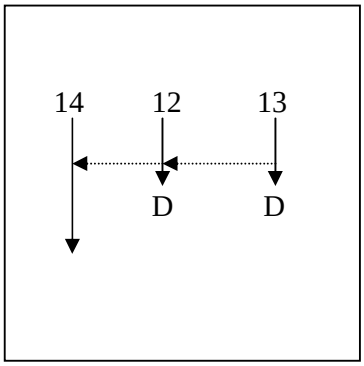
- Possesses brilliant skill and pace (explosive).
- Vision to link with wingers, fullback and support play is also important.
- Great defensive abilities.
- Good feet i.e. can step off either foot.
- Sound tactical kicking ability and must be able to execute basic kicking techniques quickly and correctly.
- Reacts quickly.
- Creative.

Special Individual Practice:

The two centres plus a wing run the ball at two defenders. The centres practice drawing the defenders and put the wing away. Here the centres can practice how long they hold on for, preferably as long as possible without being tackled in possession. Their ability to run off one another can also be practised. One handed passing is a vital skill to learn.

These two players have to remember to run straight during a match to create space. Their defence is also important.

Draw and Pass Drill:



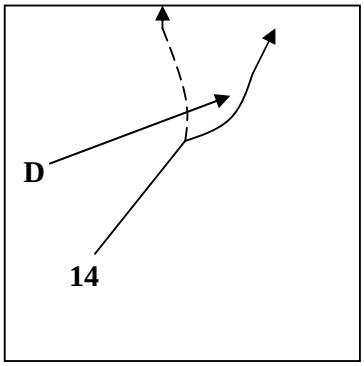
Wings: “The Finishers”

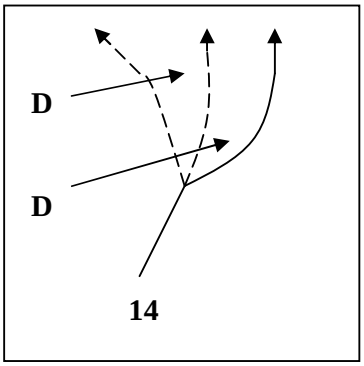
- Need to be good finishers and must posses enough pace to beat their opponent on the outside.
- Must always be aware of where the opponents and his team-mates are.
- If given room must be able to score.
- Reacts very quickly under pressure.
- Fearless ball carriers.
- Kicking skills are important e.g. chip kick and line kicking.
- Good hands.
- Supports the fullback (1/3 and 2/3 split).
- Must be able to create space by moving into a gap before taking a pass.
- Solid defender and uses the touchline to his advantage.
- Ability to score in the corner is imperative i.e. dive.

Special Individual Practice:

The wing in possession runs for the corner where one defender (fullback) tries to stop him. The defender varies his pace that he cross covers giving the winger different options, inside or outside. Another defender can be introduced which will make it even more challenging for the wing.

Beating your man Drill:





Fullback: “The Safe Keeper and Breaker”

- Needs good timing and vision to hit the line with pace.
- Must possess enough speed to join the line.
- He is often the last line of defence so he must be able to defend.
- Needs to be good at recognising where there are open spaces or gaps on the field on both attack and defence.
- Must sum up crisis situations quickly and make decisions while remaining focused.
- Retain concentration and composure when under pressure.
- General kicking ability is important i.e. line kicking and up and under.
- Catching of the high ball and positional play imperative.
- Creative
- Shows courage in defence.
- Good communicator.
- Can step off either foot.

Special Individual Practice:

The fullbacks kicking, defence and ability to catch the high ball are important and can be practiced.

For practicing the catching of the high ball one can use the flyhalf, to kick and a defender with a hit shield to apply pressure on the fullback. The fullback can practice catching the ball side on or front on, in the air or on the ground. Another supporter and defender can be introduced. The fullback can practice jumping up into the shield when he practices catching the high ball. It is important that in a game the fullback must never let the ball bounce.